Aryas, the Brahmans and the ruling class, the destitute and the aged, even prisoners. The new officials were to cater to all kinds. With prisoners their work was very definite: they were to distribute money to those who had children, help in 'unfettering of those' who had committed crimes because of the instigation of others and help in getting aged prisoners released.[12] The larger-than-life presence of this class of officers is underlined by the fact that they were said to be engaged in Pataliputra and other towns, as also in the households of Ashoka's siblings and relatives. The impression is of a considerable administrative apparatus having been put in place to oversee the practice of morality in the public and private domains, including the king's own kin.

These were events for which Ashoka provided a series of chronological markers. They spanned from 261–260 BCE till 256–255 BCE, from the Kalinga war in his eighth year (261–260 BCE) to the various ways in which, from the tenth (259–258 BCE) till the thirteenth years (256–255 BCE), he altered the administrative focus towards the creation of a moral empire. There is good reason to believe that other events and innovations in statecraft were also introduced over these years. No specificities such as 'dates' are provided for these, their existence being inferred from their inclusion alongside the record of changes in officialdom.

Ashoka's territorial canvas for moral action also now enlarges. He appears to have added a new dimension to the terms of engagement of the Mauryan realm with the states bordering his empire and beyond, towards the north-west and across the deep south. There was a range of such states and people: the Cholas, Pandyas, Satiyaputra, Tamraparni; there were the territories of the Yavana king Antiochus and chieftains neighbouring him. The basis for the existence of relations with foreign powers is in the *Arthashastra* a prelude to the monarch's expansion of his own realm through conquest. Ashoka's consideration in the matter overturned this Machiavellian thumb rule. The king's circle of influence in other kingdoms